A Fictional World Can Be a Real Experience

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Abstract

A dream can be experienced even when its room, people and events do not exist in the surrounding world. The experience and what it represents are different things. This paper applies that distinction to Matheism: if a mathematical organization constitutes a mind, its experience need not require the represented world to exist around it. The stronger claim that such a mind exists independently of any host universe also uses the premise that all suitable mathematical structures exist. The argument concerns experiencing structures, not a guarantee that every story describes a possible conscious world.

Keywords: mathematical monism, consciousness, fiction, representation, computational organization, mathematical universe hypothesis, observer measure

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1. Introduction: The Fiction Question

A dreamed room need not exist outside the dream for the experience to occur. A story, a world matching the story, and a mind imagining it are three different things. This paper asks what Matheism implies about the third: an experiencing structure whose represented surroundings need not be its actual surroundings.

Fictions commonly leave their laws and details unspecified. Incompleteness does not prove inconsistency: a sketch may admit many consistent completions. Some stories also contain incompatible assertions. A consistent mind can represent those assertions without making both true in the same respect. No frequency estimate for consistent fictional completions is established here.

The distinction between a fiction's content and the activity of imagining it is familiar. Its application here is to the realization premise of mathematical monism: identify the experiencing system separately from the world it represents.

A fiction can therefore be real as experienced content while lacking a matching external setting. Extending that observation to every proposed fiction requires showing that a suitable experiencing structure exists in each case. The argument below gives that implication conditionally; it does not infer an unlimited experience repertoire from the word imaginable.

Section 2 states the organizational proposal. Section 3 separates evidence from dreams from the additional realization premise. Sections 4 and 5 examine standalone and coupled systems. Section 6 gives the conditional inference explicitly. Sections 7 and 8 distinguish it from quantum cosmological reachability. Section

9 addresses computational limits, and section 10 relates the result to the wider programme.

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2. The Transitions Thesis

Its proposed roles for memory and self modeling require further specification and comparison with alternatives. No threshold showing that any one transition is sufficient for consciousness has been established. A state description must also be distinguished from the system's full dynamics.

A candidate computational account needs defined states and transition rules. The rules can be deterministic or stochastic. It must specify how representations, memory and access are implemented. A mathematically consistent process can contain mistaken memories and conflicting beliefs; correctness of what the system believes is not a condition of its mathematical consistency.

That distinction allows a mind to represent violations of its surrounding laws. It does not mean that any finite mind can represent arbitrary information in full detail. A label for an impossible object is an available representation without being a realization of all the properties assigned to that object.

The identification of experience with computational organization is a substantive monist proposal. It is not shared by every theory of consciousness. Its intended explanatory move is to identify the experiencing activity within structure. A successful version must also distinguish the organizations that experience from those that merely contain descriptions of experience.

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3. What Dreams Establish

A dream of flying can occur while the dreamer remains in bed. The represented flight and the process representing it have different physical descriptions. That simple example is sufficient here; neither a universal claim about what happens in every dream nor a survey of dream physiology is needed.

The dream process can be internally well defined even when its content conflicts with waking events or known physical laws. This separates consistency of the process from truth of its content.

The example supports the reality of an experience without the corresponding external event. It does not establish that the process is independent of all supporting physical organization. In the ordinary case a living brain and its environment supply that organization.

The additional question for mathematical monism is whether the relevant organization can be specified as a complete structure without that larger biological

setting. A dream alone does not prove this. It shows why the represented setting is not the same requirement as the system that supports the representation.

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4. Standalone Minds and the Realization Premise

Suppose a complete computational structure has exactly the organization sufficient for experience. A different substrate would not need an additional substance if it preserved everything relevant. Which relations must be preserved is part of the proposal, not something settled by matching a short output trace.

Matheism adds a realization premise: admissible mathematical structures exist without an external selector. The null filter motivates this position by asking what could exclude them. Absence of a specified selector is not a theorem that every consistent formal description is an implemented mind. For this paper the realization premise is stated openly, together with the organizational premise it needs.

Standalone means that the experiencing organization needs no separate world corresponding to its represented setting. Its complete mathematical specification must still include whatever states, relations, transitions and boundary information make it the proposed mind. Calling it standalone does not remove those requirements or make them free in a description length comparison.

Within the monist interpretation, a complete experiencing structure is physical in the sense relevant to its own experiences. The external mathematical description and the system's internal activity concern the same organization. A bare inscription describing that organization is a different object. Keeping that distinction prevents a sentence about a mind from counting automatically as a mind.

The central inference is therefore conditional: if the realization premise is true and the specified structure has sufficient organization for experience, its experience requires no additional nonstructural bearer. The represented world can remain fictional. This identifies what must be supplied for the argument rather than taking consistency alone as a consciousness test.

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5. Shared Dreams

Two systems can exchange signals through shared variables and transition rules. That makes a coupled system; it does not by itself merge their experiences into one subject. Communication between people and communication within a brain illustrate different organizations. A claim about subject number requires a criterion beyond the presence of a connection.

A common simulated environment could supply coordinated inputs to two experiencing systems. Their accounts might concern the same represented room even if the implementing structure has a different geometry. Shared reference requires actual relations in the implementation, not merely two matching private descriptions.

This possibility does not imply that every external world consists only of minds. Mathematical monism permits structures without observers as well as structures with observers. The stronger claim that our universe is entirely constituted by connected experiences is an additional idealist thesis, not a consequence of the coupled simulation example.

Whitehead and Sprigge offer historical comparisons for accounts placing experience centrally. Their systems are not identified with the computational proposal here. Establishing that proposal's contribution requires the explicit conditional argument and the distinctions below, rather than claiming that every consistent universe is a network of minds.

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6. The Fiction Question Reframed

The conditional inference can be stated in three premises. First, a particular structure S is admissible under the realization principle. Second, S has the organization sufficient for experience. Third, an experience in S represents a specified fictional content F. Under those premises an experience of F is realized. Nothing in that inference makes F a true description of S's external surroundings.

For example, an experience of a room whose depicted features shift inconsistently can have a consistent sequence of implementing states. The sequence need not implement a physical room possessing incompatible dimensions at once. Likewise, someone can read a story about Hogwarts without a matching school existing. The realized event is the experience, including whatever detail it actually contains.

The quantifiers matter. The conditional inference applies to each S for which its premises hold. The claim that every fiction is experienced adds a further assertion: for every proposed F there exists a suitable S. A general construction or other argument for that assertion has not been given here. A title cannot replace it.

This preserves a substantive result for the monist position. Failure to realize a narrative as an external world does not rule out its realization as experienced content. The second realization has its own conditions, and need not inherit every physical claim made by the narrative.

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7. Fluctuation Observers: Formation, Experience and Weight

A Boltzmann observer is not disqualified simply because its formation differs from biological development. If a fluctuation implements all the organization sufficient for experience, the organizational account attributes experience to it. Whether a proposed fluctuation actually does so remains a physical and philosophical question.

Everettian dynamics does not guarantee continual branching in every state. Nor is every nonzero basis component a functioning observer. The Hamiltonian, initial state and development of correlated records matter. A state with a brain shaped projection is not automatically a complete history of a conscious process.

Its corrected analysis does not infer nonergodicity from determinism. A unitary process can change zero coefficients in a chosen basis into nonzero ones. Both a formation claim and an exclusion claim therefore need the relevant dynamics.

Quantum tunneling illustrates behavior unavailable to a classical trajectory. It is not a general existence proof for arbitrary brains. Likewise, paths in a path integral should not each be counted as separate experienced histories. The consciousness question begins once a model supplies the required organization.

Description length comparisons must allow both candidates their shortest available generative accounts. A fluctuation need not be specified particle by particle if a cosmological generator produces it. The calculation must include how that event is selected and weighted. Algorithmic probability alone supplies no completed result that ordinary observers dominate fluctuation observers.

A minimal duration for experience is not derived in this paper. Calling an operation one transition does not fix its physical duration, causal depth or internal organization. An entire computation can be packaged as one formal update by changing the description. The criterion must concern the implemented organization, not the granularity of the notation.

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8. Dynamics, Gravity and Reachability

A specified quantum cosmology supplies a state and dynamics, not merely a list of particle positions. Even classical GR includes gravitational degrees of freedom and initial constraints. The local stress energy tensor does not uniquely determine the full spacetime geometry: vacuum gravitational waves provide a familiar counterexample. A complete cosmological account must specify the relevant gravitational data as well.

Branches, where the description is applicable, share the specified fundamental dynamics. They may differ in effective parameters through different field states. Permission under a law is still weaker than reachability from the selected initial

condition. These distinctions matter when identifying which candidate minds a cosmology actually implements.

A mind representable in our mathematical language is not thereby reached by our wavefunction. A proposed computational architecture might be simulable under our laws but never implemented in our actual history. Neither representability nor simulation capability alone closes that gap.

The conditional experience argument does not require a proof that Level III contains Level IV. It asks what follows if a suitable experiencing structure is realized. Whether our cosmology supplies that structure and with what measure remains an independent task.

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9. What Undecidability Establishes

To establish that every proposed fiction is experienced somewhere, one would need an account of which descriptions admit an experiencing implementation. The familiar observation that some general computational questions are undecidable does not by itself settle this particular classification.

The halting theorem states that no algorithm decides, for every program and input, whether that computation halts. A nonhalting program may nevertheless produce an ongoing stream of finite outputs. Nontermination is therefore different from incomputability of a requested function. Neither fact directly establishes a boundary of possible consciousness.

Under the proposed organizational identity, possible experiences are the experiences of admissible structures with the required organization. This defines the target of an account. It does not provide a procedure for recognizing those structures or independently characterize their phenomenal content.

An undecidability theorem for that recognition problem would need an effective input language, a definite organizational criterion and a reduction from a known undecidable problem, or an equivalent proof. No such reduction is supplied here. General undecidability of sufficiently expressive formal problems is not a theorem that every particular candidate mind is undecidable.

Individual implementations may be specified and investigated even when no general decision method exists. The useful research task is to identify the organization and test restricted classes of candidates. This preserves the distinction between a determinate proposal and our ability to establish whether it holds.

9.1 Relation to existing accounts of imagination and fiction

Williamson's discussion of knowing through imagination concerns how imagination can support modal knowledge. Imagining a scene and establishing that its represented events are possible remain different achievements. The present paper uses that distinction without claiming to refute or strengthen Williamson's

account. A mind can consistently entertain mutually incompatible propositions without establishing either as true.

Walton's account treats works of fiction as props governing games of make believe. What a work prescribes imagining, what a reader actually imagines and what occurs outside the game are distinct. The computational proposal concerns the second: the implementing activity of an actual experience. It does not equate fictional truth with the reader's experienced content or replace the conventions governing the game.

The proposed contribution is consequently narrow: under explicit monist premises, the reality of an experience can be separated from the realization of its represented world. This is a conditional ontological application of familiar distinctions, not a claim to have supplied foundations previously absent from the philosophy of fiction.

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10. Connection to the Broader Program

Those papers do not establish the Standard Model, the cosmic matter asymmetry or observer measures from a simplicity prior alone.

This leaves room for different structures: universes with no observers, universes with many, and candidate minds with no separate represented environment. A claim that all are mathematical gives them a common ontology. It does not erase differences in their organization or settle their relative observational weight.

The standalone case should be assessed by specifying its complete dynamics and the criterion it satisfies. If the realization premise covers that structure, the monist account attributes experience without adding a host world in which the depicted story is true. That is the strongest conclusion established by the stated argument.

A generative account can explain an elaborate mind through compact laws and boundary conditions. A standalone mind must also have its structure explained, but it need not be specified as a literal list of every component: it could have a compact generator. The measure comparison must charge both accounts on equal terms. The solid developmental point is that a successful history from an initially unorganized state produces the organization required for the observers it contains. Its total description can remain short.

Imagination can represent mathematical possibilities as well as confused or incomplete descriptions. It is not evidence of a causal channel to another realized world. The concrete experiencing process is the object this argument concerns. Its content must be distinguished from whatever would make that content true externally.

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11. Conclusion

A represented world can be fictional while the experience representing it is real. Under the proposed identity of mind and organization, a suitable mathematical mind supplies that experience. Its existence without a host universe additionally uses the stated realization premise.

The same criterion for experience must apply whatever the mind's origin. Formation, functioning and relative frequency are different questions. A complete account should specify the organization, what it represents and why it meets the criterion.

The represented room may be fictional. The experience of it can be real.

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